



PATIENTS, NOT CRIMINALS

THE PORTUGUESE DRUG STRATEGY (2000)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Decriminalizing drug use

BEFORE

1868 Under the UK's Pharmacy Act, only qualified pharmacists are allowed to buy and sell dangerous drugs and poisons.

1912 The International Opium Convention, the first international drug control treaty, is adopted. It comes into force globally in 1919.

1971 US president Richard Nixon calls for a "war on drugs" to combat rising drug abuse.

AFTER

2012 Washington and Colorado become the first two US states to decriminalize the personal use of cannabis.

2014 The World Health Organization calls for drug use to be decriminalized.

2019 Thirty-one UN agencies endorse the decriminalization of drug use.

In 2000, Portugal passed legislation to decriminalize the use of previously illegal drugs, such as heroin and cocaine. The aim was to tackle a spiraling addiction problem by treating rather than punishing drug users—a radical move in a nation famed for its conservatism.

During the 1800s, Western views of drug use had hardened as opium addiction levels increased. Although in 1839 and 1856, the UK had twice gone to war with China to protect the lucrative opium trade, it had been the first country (in 1868) to pass a modern law restricting the sale of drugs and poisons. In the

20th century, despite a succession of international drug control treaties and ever harsher national laws that criminalized drug use as well as drug trafficking, both continued to proliferate worldwide.

Tackling the problem

Under the authoritarian regime of António de Oliveira Salazar, its prime minister from 1932 to 1968, Portugal missed the explosion in drug use that other countries experienced in the 1960s. In 1974, 3 years after his death, the regime collapsed in a bloodless revolution that opened up the country to international trade, and cannabis and heroin flooded in.

Portugal initially reacted with a crackdown that punished drug users and traffickers, but had little effect. In 1983, however, a new law gave drug users the option to accept treatment and suspend criminal punishment. In 1987, the Taipas Center, funded by the Ministry of Health and led by public health campaigner Dr. João Castelo-Branco Goulão, opened in Lisbon, serving as a model for other treatment centers across Portugal. As drug use continued to rise, a 1998 government report backed



There is no correlation between the harshness of drug laws and the incidence of drug-taking.

The Economist
Leader, May 5, 2009

